

International AS and A-level Psychology (9685) PS01 Introductory Topics in Psychology Report on the examination

June 2024

REPORT ON EXAMINATION: INTERNATIONAL AS PSYCHOLOGY (9685) PS01 JUNE 2024

Performance on this exam was comparable to previous series, with some students demonstrating excellent psychological knowledge and understanding. Overall, students performed better on questions requiring AO1 skills, but often did not achieve the same level of success on questions that required AO3 skills. For these AO3 questions, students tended to identify relevant evaluation issues but did not follow these up with effective elaboration. AO3 skills are the hardest to master, but I would strongly recommend that teachers continue to focus on their students' evaluative skills, especially on linking their points made back to the issue that they are evaluating.

AO2 skills continue to show development. Many students were able to effectively use their knowledge and understanding, applying this in a successful way to the novel scenarios presented in the paper. Some students however continue to struggle with AO2 questions and write their responses without engaging and linking to the scenario given, or they simply rewrite large sections of the scenario that had been provided within their response. This often results in very few marks being gained.

QUESTION 01

This question was answered correctly by most students. However, some provided vague answers such as simply stating that the capacity was 'limited,' whilst others incorrectly stated either the duration or coding of STM as their response. It is important that students read the question carefully to ensure that they understand exactly what they are being asked for in their answer. There were also a few incorrect statements of the capacity, which should have been stated as 7 ± 2 (or 5-9), however there was a variety of inaccurate and muddled responses, such as stating -2 to +7.

QUESTION 02

Many students answered this question well, showing a good understanding of research into the duration of STM, with most opting to focus on Peterson & Peterson's trigram experiment. The main issue that held many students back however was the lack of focus on the wording of the question. The question asked students 'how' duration of STM has been investigated. Consequently, their responses should have been fully focused on the procedures involved in the study. However, many gave unnecessary detail on the findings and/or conclusions, which were not creditworthy. One of the main issues was a lack of clarity and detail over some elements of the experimental procedure, eg, not mentioning the use of a distractor task to prevent rehearsal, or reference to the varying intervals of time that the participants were distracted for, before recalling the information/trigram.

Some students confused their answers with other research into the features of memory, for example, several responses offered research into the duration of STM using Sperling's research into the sensory register.

QUESTION 03

Most students were able to achieve some marks for this question, with many gaining either top of level 1 or bottom of level 2. Whilst most responses were accurate and showed some understanding of how the multi-store model of memory could be applied to the conversation between Aamna and Rayan, many lacked an element of depth and/or detail. Often students simply focused on how Aamna was not rehearsing/able to concentrate (because of the music), whereas Rayan could

rehearse/concentrate (because it was quiet). Although responses of this nature could receive some credit, it was often limited to level 1 as there was little understanding demonstrated of how the MSM could be used to account for this.

QUESTION 04

There was a good range of responses provided for this question, with many students able to achieve at least 2 out of the 3 marks available. The main issue preventing some from achieving the full 3 marks was a lack of clarity about how and why the issue they identified was limitation of the MSM. Additionally, some students focused their limitation on possible limitations of research studies into the MSM. To make these types of limitations creditworthy, students must ensure they highlight how and why issues with the research is a limitation for the MSM itself.

QUESTION 05

Most students were able to gain some credit on this question, with a significant proportion able to gain either 3 or the full 4 marks available. However, there were several issues that arose. Firstly, students must be wary of providing obvious answers that cannot receive credit. For example, simply stating that the visuo-spatial sketchpad deals with 'visual' and 'spatial' information. This is not enough specific detail to gain any credit.

In reference to the episodic buffer, several focused their response on how this is a 'new' element of the model. Whilst this is somewhat true, based on the idea that the model was reimagined in 2000, when the episodic buffer was added. However, this was 24 years ago, with the original model being proposed in 1974. Therefore, the episodic buffer has been present in the model almost as long as it was absent. Responses that solely focused their description of the episodic buffer around it being 'new' rarely received any credit as it provides no actual information about the episodic buffer's role.

QUESTION 06

Whilst most students were able to select the correct type of long-term memory, there were surprisingly many who did not get this question correct.

QUESTION 07.1 & 07.2

Question 07.1 was usually answered well by most students. However, some lost focus on the command word of 'state' and provided unnecessarily lengthy explanations. These often still got credit providing the key terms for the possible factors were included, such as referencing leading questions or post-event discussion.

Question 07.2 was also answered well by most students. However, some responses were generic and not focused on the scenario, specifically, how the identified factor would affect Norman's eyewitness testimony.

QUESTION 08.1

This question was usually answered very well, with many students able to gain full marks. Most were able to name and outline all four techniques of the cognitive interview clearly and accurately with some providing reference to elements of the enhanced cognitive interview as well. However, several responses simply named some of the elements of the cognitive interview and these could only gain a maximum of 1 mark. Alternatively, some tried to explain the elements by simply re-naming them.

For example, stating that one element of the cognitive interview is to recall everything, this is when the witness is asked to recall everything. Students must be more mindful of not simply re-writing the name as part of their explanation of something.

QUESTION 08.2

Most students were able to perform reasonably well on this question, with many able to provide a level 2 response. However, many responses did not clarify how and why their chosen issues were either strengths or limitations of the cognitive interview overall.

There was a very good demonstration of knowledge of relevant studies into the cognitive interview. However, some students provided lengthy explanations of the procedures of these studies. When asked to provide critical appraisal, information about studies cannot gain credit until the findings and conclusions are included and links are made to how and why the research provides support or criticism of the issue being evaluated.

QUESTION 09

There were many good answers provided for this question, with some students demonstrating an excellent understanding of Asch's research into the effects of group size and conformity. The best responses were able to accurately explain the different conformity percentages in relation to the changing size of the group's majority. These responses also understood that conformity levels stopped rising significantly once the majority reaches 3.

It was nice to see that many of the students who performed well on this question only provided detail about the findings, as requested in the question, with very few responses providing unnecessary details of Asch's procedures or conclusions.

However, some inaccuracies were evident. The main issue was responses expressing Asch's results as a correlation, eg as group size increases so does conformity. It is incorrect to state this as, while conformity does increase steadily at first, it stops increasing once the majority reaches 5 when it then begins to plateau and is therefore not a correlation.

QUESTION 10

Performance on this question was similar to question 04, with many able to achieve at least 2 out of the 3 marks available. Lots of good and accurate answers were provided, often written in a clear way, using key psychological terminology. However, some students provided generic evaluations, usually based around ecological validity. This can be a valid limitation, but some of these responses were written in a non-specific way which could have been applied to any psychological laboratory experiment. Additionally, some students focused on the ethics of Asch's study. Again, these responses were often generic, simply referencing deception as an issue, and did not ultimately address why being unethical is a limitation of Asch's research.

QUESTION 11

Many performed well on this question with the majority managing to produce a level 2 response. Some answers lost focus on the question and provided lengthy and unnecessary general explanations of what normative influence and informational influence are. The best responses demonstrated a good understanding of how both explanations of conformity could relate specifically to what John and Rebecca discussed in their conversation.

QUESTION 12

This question was poorly answered overall, with only a small number of students managing to produce a response worthy of a level 3 mark. A lack of focus on the question was the downfall for many students. Many simply described normative and/or informational influence, rather than evaluating these explanations for conformity. As with question 08.2, many also provided lengthy descriptions of research into conformity, such as Asch, Jenness or Sherif, but few could use these studies in any meaningful way to evaluate the explanations for conformity. Often, a lack of effectiveness held some responses back. Students must link their evaluation issues back to the point at hand in terms of how and why their issue supports or criticises the area they have been asked to evaluate.

QUESTION 13

There were many good and concise answers given for this question which were able to explain agentic state both clearly and accurately. However, some student responses confused agentic state with legitimacy of authority, merging both elements into an unclear response that lacked specific focus on the agentic state. Additionally, some simply stated that agentic state is when you act as an agent for someone. This is too vague and lacks clarity and detail. The key aspect of agentic state is in relation to the person not feeling responsible for their actions. This was an important statement to make and without it, responses rarely gained more than 1 mark.

QUESTION 14

Despite some reasonable answers to this question, most were unable to move beyond a level 2 response. Although a good understanding of both internal and external locus of control was demonstrated, few were able to explain the link between locus of control and resistance to social influence.

Additionally, many were unable to move beyond level 2 as they only described locus of control, making no attempt to provide any discussion through providing strengths and limitations of locus of control as an explanation for social influence.

Some responses also went off-topic, providing lengthy and often irrelevant explanations of other areas of the social influence topic that had not been asked for, such as social support. Reference to these areas could receive credit, provided direct comparisons with locus of control were made, however, most responses did not do this.

Finally, some provided vague and often muddled explanations of research into locus of control, focusing on the original studies of Milgram or Asch and trying to, inappropriately, link these to locus of control. Locus of control was only investigated in later replications, such as Milgram & Elms.

QUESTION 15

Many students were able to do well on this question, identifying relevant characteristics of phobias and clearly linking these to the behaviour shown by Monik. However, there were several common issues. Firstly, many responses simply stated 'cognitive,' 'behavioural' and 'emotional' as their answers. These are categories of characteristics of psychological disorders and not the actual characteristics themselves and therefore no credit could be received. Additionally, there were many responses which simply re-wrote the information, often word-for-word, that had been provided in the scenario. For example, these stated that one characteristic that Monik has is that he believes that all cats are dangerous and will hurt him. This had already been given in the scenario. Students

need to remember that, although references to the scenario are required, their answers must go beyond simply re-writing the information that has already been provided.

QUESTION 16

Many students were able to demonstrate a good understanding of flooding as a treatment for phobias. However, while most did summarise the basic idea of flooding, in terms of exposing the person to their phobia in full without the ability to escape, few progressed onto explaining the actual psychology behind flooding. This limited responses to top of level 1 or bottom of level 2. To achieve higher marks, students needed to demonstrate that they understood how flooding worked on a psychological level. For example, they should have explained that anxiety can only stay high for a short period of time before naturally reducing. This causes the extinction of the CS-CR association that has become the phobia. Finally, the CS becomes a NS again.

QUESTION 17

Some students were able to provide an excellent answer to this question which demonstrated a good knowledge of the cognitive explanations of depression, as well as some effective and thorough evaluation points. However, a number of students provided little more than just a list of key concepts. For example, they simply listing the three parts of the negative triad or what the A, B and C stood for in Ellis' ABC model, without any effort to provide further detail or explanation. Answers like these rarely moved beyond a level 2.

One common recurring issue was a loss of focus on the question being asked. For example, several students started their essay by explaining the cognitive explanations of depression. Then, they soon started writing, at length, about the use of CBT as a treatment for depression. Reference to CBT was creditworthy when used appropriately, such as to support the cognitive explanations. However, these responses focused mostly on CBT as a treatment of depression, describing the process in depth and then evaluating it as a treatment. It is important that students remain focused on the requirements of the question within their answer.